Two Odd Tales

Something a little Different

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Tale 1

The Last Laugh

A Kid's Mystery

It was a weird, crawly, creepy, slimy thing, but Harry didn't mind; he stuck his hands in his pockets even harder and laughed at it.

Harry was standing in front of his garden wall and just three feet away was the 'thing'. It slithered down the rough stones without making a sound.

"Hah! You don't scare me! I've won the bet. The time is nearly up and I'm not going to move."

A little earlier he had made a bet with his sister that he could stand still for 10 whole minutes no matter what happened. She had then walked towards the house with her hands in her pockets, occasionally looking over her shoulder.

"I'll be watching you," she taunted as she waked away.

Harry started counting down the 10 minutes as soon as she left, but nothing had happened till now. With only two or three minutes to go, something had appeared from the other side of the wall. It had perched on top for a few

minutes before it started creeping down towards him, inch by inch.

Harry had no doubt at all that Anne was there, in their neighbour's garden, crouching behind that very wall.

"Anne!" called Harry. "That is the silliest thing I've ever seen." He laughed loudly and rocked back and forward a little. The creature stopped.

"I didn't move. I didn't; my feet are still in the same place. I know it's you. Come out and see for yourself." There was no answer. "Anne?" Still no answer.

"Ok then, in two minutes I am going to move and grab your silly puppet."

However, at that very moment, Anne was being scolded by their neighbour, Mr. Potts, for accidentally trampling on his prize marrow as she crept past his greenhouse.

She was sorry and had apologised repeatedly, but Mr. Potts was delivering one of his meaningful lectures so there was nothing to do but stand there and listen.

She looked past him at the garden wall. "Oh, what is happening on the other side?" she said to herself. Had he moved? She wondered. Had her trick worked?

The creepy thing was getting closer, and Harry could now see its eyes. He could see the two large circles peeping out above the great, round, hairy head six inches wide. The rest of its body slithered behind. It was about two or three feet long; grey and leathery. Harry looked at the eyes. The eyes looked back at Harry.

It was then that Harry stopped laughing and called out. "Anne, are you there?" There was no answer. "Anne?" he called again. Still nothing.

Then he heard the door of Mr. Potts' shed squeak open and he could hear him talking to someone.

"Off you go now and look for your ball. Be careful of my Begonias down there!"

The next thing he heard was Anne's voice, and it sounded as though she was also very close to the shed.

"I will be really careful, I will, Mr. Potts. Sorry about your marrow," came her reply.

He heard a shed door being shut and footsteps running away. He realized Anne was not the one pulling this thing's strings and his heart stopped a beat. The creepy thing was now crawling towards him along the ground. Its two enormous eyes seemed to stare as hard at him as he stared at it.

"Go away!" shouted Harry, and the thing blinked at the noise. "Go away! Shoo!" he yelled. He couldn't have moved if he had wanted to because he was now rooted to the spot and the 'thing' was getting closer.

The noise of Anne's footsteps got louder, and she was now clattering down the garden path on Harry's side of the fence. The sudden increase in noise made the creature jump. It stopped, whirled around, and shot like a streak of lightning into the bushes.

"Have you moved?" called Anne. "Bet you have."

"No I did not," snapped Harry. "What on earth WAS that?"

"Oh, you mean it worked?" said Anne, and started laughing with delight.

She was still laughing as she walked over and picked up a bundle of fur and plastic.

"This thing?" She held it up, and a battery fell out.

"I was dying to see if you would move when you saw it."

Harry examined it and laughed, partly with relief and partly because it looked so ridiculous.

"It didn't fool me for a minute," he said and threw it

back at her. "Show me how to set it up," he said, still a little confused how it could have fooled him.

Anne walked back up the path, but Harry had the strangest feeling that something was not quite right. He paused for a minute for a last look around.

"Come on," said Anne and signalled for him to hurry. He shrugged off the feeling and ran up the path after her.

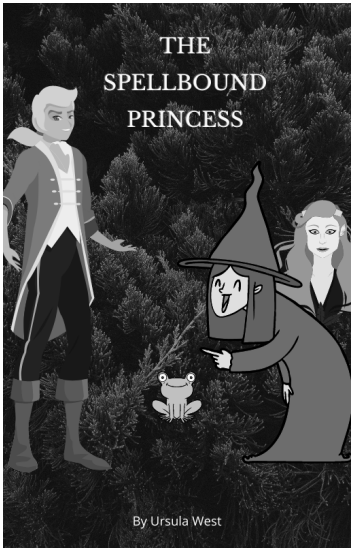
As they both went, two large round eyes looked at him from a distance, but Harry didn't see them.

Nor did he hear the soft chuckling noise and the great wide grin on the round, furry face as something, somewhere in the bushes, was having the last laugh.

Tale 2

The Spellbound Princess

Fairytale



Once upon a time, there was a prince who went to a strange, unknown country.

As he walked along, he came upon a princess sitting on a stool in a little wooden shed.

"Why are you sitting there?" said the prince, but the princess did not answer. She just sat there looking like a statue.

She looked so beautiful that the prince thought to himself she was just the perfect bride for him. In fact, he had set out on his mission to find himself just such a princess and this was the fourteenth country he had visited. He had been getting a little fed up with his quest and if he had not found this beautiful stranded maiden, he might have turned around and gone home that very minute.

He shook her, but still she did not move. He sang her a little song (the birds flew away holding their ears) but still, she did not move.

"To be true!" exclaimed the prince. "She must be enchanted."

Just then, he heard the awful cackle of an old, wicked witch.

"Get away!" she shouted at him in the most horrid, rasping voice he had ever heard. But the prince stood his ground for love of the maiden.

"No, why should I?" he said.

"This is why!" cackled the witch and pointed a crooked finger at him. Out of nowhere, an enormous bumpy, scaled dragon appeared and got ready to frazzle him to cinders. He turned and ran for cover so that the dragon's breath only caught his coat tails and singed his bottom rather badly.

He dashed off to the riverbank and sat down in the river. With a sizzle and frizzle, the fire went out, and the prince was much relieved. Back he went to rescue his love.

The dragon had gone, but the old witch still stood there hovering over the enchanted princess. The prince had some plans of his own by now. Out of his bag, he produced a handy pack of dynamite and lit the fuse.

"Here!" he said, "catch this." And he threw the dynamite into the witch's hands. The witch staggered back into her own house and there was an enormous bang.

BOOM!!

For a moment there was complete silence and then the house slowly started to move up in the air and, just as slowly, came back down. The door opened and there was the witch holding the dynamite in her ugly hands

"Ha!" she said wickedly. "You will have to do better than that, boy!"

"Release the princess!" shouted the prince, "or I will." He paused.

"You will what?" cackled the witch.

"I, I, I'll think of something."

"Be quick." said the witch, "because now I must move her to a new secret hiding place. It's all your own fault, you stupid oaf! You should have left us alone."

The witch wrapped her bony arms about the neck of the princess and waved the prince away.

"I'll be back ....you old hag. You have lost your grip on her now. I know it in my bones."

"Be off with you! You young imp, you and your bones!"

The prince fell to the ground in a heap beside the river. He buried his head in his hands in utter despair. As he sat there, a small green frog jumped across his path. Like a flash of lightning, he caught it and jumped to his feet.

"That's it!" he shouted and began running back to the witch, holding the little green frog tightly in his hands. He reached the witch just as she was preparing a spell to whisk away the princess to a new place.

"You again!" mumbled the witch, getting a little tired by his interruptions. "If you take a step further, I will turn you into a frog."

"That's what I suspected," said the prince but can you change a frog into a prince when some other witch has turned it into a frog? I have been told that only senior witches can undo other witch's spells and my friend ...er, George..here, has been a frog for some time now. How about it then? Are you as powerful as that?"

"Give it here, you goat!" snapped the witch and then I will do the same to you." She stuck out her scrawny hand to grab hold of the frog. Just as the prince had guessed, she did not want to miss the chance of showing off her miserable powers.

"But wait," said the prince, drawing it back. "First, we must make a pact, a magic pact. If you cannot do this, you must release the princess from her spell."

"And if I do manage to do what you have said?" queried the witch.

The prince pretended to look worried and answered with fake bravery, "Then I, too, will fall under your evil magic. But I made a promise to my friend, Prince George. It must be done."

"It is done," cackled the old hag and waved her wand in the air. "I made the magic pact. Now give me the wretched creature."

The prince stroked the little green frog. "Don't worry George", he whispered gently. "You will soon be yourself again." He pretended to smile and handed the little creature to the witch.

His plan depended solely on the truth that this was indeed an ordinary frog. He knew enough to know that the witch's spell would backfire if she tried to reverse a spell that had never existed.

However, until this moment, he had never thought of the possibility that this little green frog could really be a

prince under a spell. He looked at the frog in the witch's hand and his stomach suddenly dropped into his boots. His throat went dry, and his eyes looked glazed, very much like his spellbound princess.

"What's the matter, lovey?" cooed the witch. "Didn't you know I put all my frog princes down by that river? A little nervous now, are we?"

She gave an ear-piercing yell and opened a book of spells, pinning down its pages with an old bone.

"In this book is the most powerful reversal spell known to witches." crooned the old hag.

"Say goodbye to this fair world, my pretty one. You are about to die!"

With great fuss and drama, she started the incantation. Great clouds of smoke ascended around her. The book and the table on which sat the little green frog disappeared from view. When the clouds subsided, the witch was no longer to be seen. Instead, sitting beside the book of spells was not one, but TWO little green frogs.

"It worked!!" shouted the prince and pounced forward to catch the princess before she fell off the stool.

The princess opened her eyes and instantly fell madly in love with the handsome prince (as was to be expected).

The witch, however, never quite knew what happened. At first she was hopping mad to find herself sitting on a table, but the frog squatting next to her seemed to have a jolly glint in his eyes.

It might have been the reversal spell or maybe just the weather, but a mad, impetuous impulse came over her and she couldn't help wishing that he would ask her to marry him.

The little green frogs were last seen holding hands down by the riverside and no doubt lived hoppily ever after.

Once the prince and princess had stopped smiling at each other, they both decided to go back to his kingdom, and get married as soon as the dress was ready. Then they lived happily ever after, except for being slightly nervous about little green frogs.